

Make an Army memo with AI. Start here.

AI FUNDAMENTALS IN HEALTH CARE
COACHING NOTE · DR. JARED BLACK

You watched me generate an AR 25-50 memo in seconds during class and asked how it's done. Here it is — the simple way first. Do this once and you'll have a clean, compliant MFR tonight.

You don't learn to code.

The AI writes the formatting for you. You just copy it, paste it, and tidy up a little — nothing to learn.

You install nothing.

The fast path runs entirely in your web browser. No software, no IT ticket.

About 15 minutes.

That's the first time, while you find the buttons. After that it's about 3 minutes a memo.

Why not just use Word? In Word, you'd line up the exact AR 25-50 margins, fonts, and spacing yourself. Here, a free website does that part for you, so you only deal with the words. It won't be perfect on the first try (see the heads-up below), but it gets you most of the way there, fast.

THE FAST PATH — DO THIS TONIGHT

Chat AI → Overleaf

BROWSER ONLY · ~15 MIN FIRST TIME

YOU'LL NEED · Any chat-based AI — [Ask Sage](#) (the DoD-authorized, CUI-approved one), or ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini for non-sensitive memos — and a free [Overleaf](#) account. Plus the attached **STARTER KIT** (a zip — just unzip it).

For sensitive (CUI) memos, use [asksage.ai](#) (Army CAC users sign in at [chat.genai.army.mil](#)). For routine memos, any chatbot you already have works.

PART A · WRITE IT (IN THE CHAT)

- 1 Unzip the starter kit. (Nothing goes to the AI — you'll only upload two files to Overleaf later.)
- 2 Open your AI (Ask Sage, ChatGPT, or Claude) and start a new chat. If it asks you to choose a model, pick the newest one.
- 3 From the kit, open `sample-prompt.md`, copy everything in it, and paste it into the chat. The formatting instructions are already inside — you don't attach anything.
- 4 Where the prompt shows `[brackets]`, type in your memo details. Then send.
- 5 The AI answers with a block of formatting text. Copy **only that text** — it should start with `\documentclass`. If the AI added ````` marks or sentences around it, leave those out.

PART B · GET THE PDF (OVERLEAF)

- 1 Go to [overleaf.com](#) → sign up free → **New Project** → Blank Project.
- 2 Click **Upload** and add two files from the kit: `armymemo.cls` and `D0Db1.pdf`.
- 3 Delete the sample text in the editing box and paste in what you copied from the AI.
- 4 **Important:** open the **Menu (top-left)** and set "Compiler" to **LuaLaTeX** — Overleaf's default won't work here. Then click **Recompile**.
- 5 Click **Download PDF**. That's your memo.
- 6 **Blank lines?** An underline shows wherever the AI didn't have a detail. In the text, find the matching `\rule{...}`, type your information over it, and Recompile.

Heads up — expect a little fiddling. This is a copy-paste process, not a one-click button. The first time, expect some back-and-forth: now and then the AI adds ````` marks or a stray sentence (just delete them), or gives text that won't turn into a PDF (paste the error back into the chat and ask it to fix it). And you'll polish the wording and fill in blanks before it's right. Still much faster than formatting by hand.

Two non-negotiables — these matter more than any step above

1. Mind where the words go. Ask Sage is a government, CUI-approved system — fine for sensitive memo content. **Overleaf and commercial chatbots are not.** Never paste CUI, PHI, or real PII into them. **If your memo contains CUI, skip Overleaf** — make the PDF on your own computer instead (see the back), so nothing leaves your machine.

2. You sign it, you own it. AI invents names, dates, and regulation numbers with total confidence — a wrong reg number looks exactly as authoritative as a right one. The sample prompt tells it to leave blanks instead of guessing. Read every line before it goes out; "the AI wrote it" is not a defense.

OPTIONAL

The fast path above is a complete, permanent solution — many people never need more. If you make memos often, here are two setups that remove the copy-paste. Skip this page until you want it.

First, the one bit of jargon. That block of formatting text has a name — **LaTeX** (say “LAY-tek”). Overleaf is just a free website that turns it into the finished PDF. Every memo comes out correctly formatted because of one file in the kit, `armymemo.cls` — the formatting rulebook. You and the AI supply the words; it handles the layout. The two options below do the same thing, without copying text between two websites.

TWO FASTER SETUPS

Claude Cowork

AN APP ON YOUR COMPUTER · WRITES THE FILE FOR YOU

Need: the [Claude desktop app](#) ([Cowork](#), on any paid plan — Pro or higher).

- Put the starter-kit folder in your Documents folder.
- Open the app, click **Cowork**, point it at that folder, grant access.
- Tell it: “Using the armymemo template here, write an MFR about [your facts]. Save it as a new .tex file. Don’t make anything up — leave blanks.”
- It writes the file for you. For the PDF, hand the file to Overleaf, or make it on your computer if you’ve installed the software (below).

Claude Code in VS Code

THE WAY I DO IT IN CLASS · MOST SETUP, LEAST EFFORT AFTER

Need: VS Code, Claude Code, and LaTeX installed (below). One-time setup; then it’s the fastest.

- Open a folder containing `armymemo.cls` + `D0Db1.pdf` in VS Code; start Claude Code.
- Ask in plain English: “Using armymemo.cls here, write an MFR about [facts], leave blanks for anything missing, then compile twice with lualatex and open the PDF.”
- It writes the memo, turns it into a PDF, and opens it — no copy-paste, and nothing leaves your machine.
- Iterate by talking. (In class I use a custom `/memo` skill that also auto-loads the regs — [AR 25-50](#), the [Tongue & Quill](#) — you can build one once you’re comfortable.)

MAKING THE PDF ON YOUR OWN COMPUTER (NEEDED FOR BOTH OPTIONS, AND FOR ANY CUI MEMO)

This replaces Overleaf with free software on your machine. Install [MacTeX](#) ([tug.org/mactex](#), for Mac) or [TeX Live](#) ([tug.org/texlive](#), for Windows/Linux) — a one-time download, a few GB. Keep `armymemo.cls` and `D0Db1.pdf` in the same folder as your memo file, then run this command twice: `lualatex memo.tex && lualatex memo.tex`. Because nothing leaves your computer, this path is safe for CUI. (The memo uses Times New Roman + Arial; Mac and Overleaf already have them, a bare Linux machine may need the `msttcorefonts` package first.)

WHICH IS WHICH

METHOD	SETUP	EFFORT PER MEMO	STAYS ON YOUR COMPUTER?	BEST FOR
Chat AI → Overleaf	None — browser only	~3 min (copy-paste)	No — uses Overleaf	Everyone’s starting point; all most people need
Claude Cowork	Desktop app, paid plan	~2 min, no copy-paste	Writing yes; PDF if LaTeX installed	Frequent memos, non-technical
Claude Code	Most — app + LaTeX	Fastest — one line	Yes — fully local (CUI-safe)	Power users; sensitive content

WHAT’S IN THE STARTER KIT (ATTACHED ZIP)

- `sample-prompt.md` — the ready-to-paste prompt for Part A (no uploads).
- `D0Db1.pdf` — the DoD seal. Upload to Overleaf too.
- `mfr-template.tex` — a blank fill-in memo, if you’d rather start by hand.
- `digsig.sty` — optional; ignore unless you add a digital signature.

- `armymemo.cls` — the rulebook (all AR 25-50 formatting). Upload to Overleaf.
- `mfr-template-EXAMPLE-output.pdf` — what a finished memo looks like.
- `README.txt` — the same steps, in the folder.

Bottom line: do the fast path first — once you’ve found the buttons, you’ll have a compliant MFR in about 15 minutes, and you never have to touch the other two methods unless you want to go faster. — Dr. Jared Black